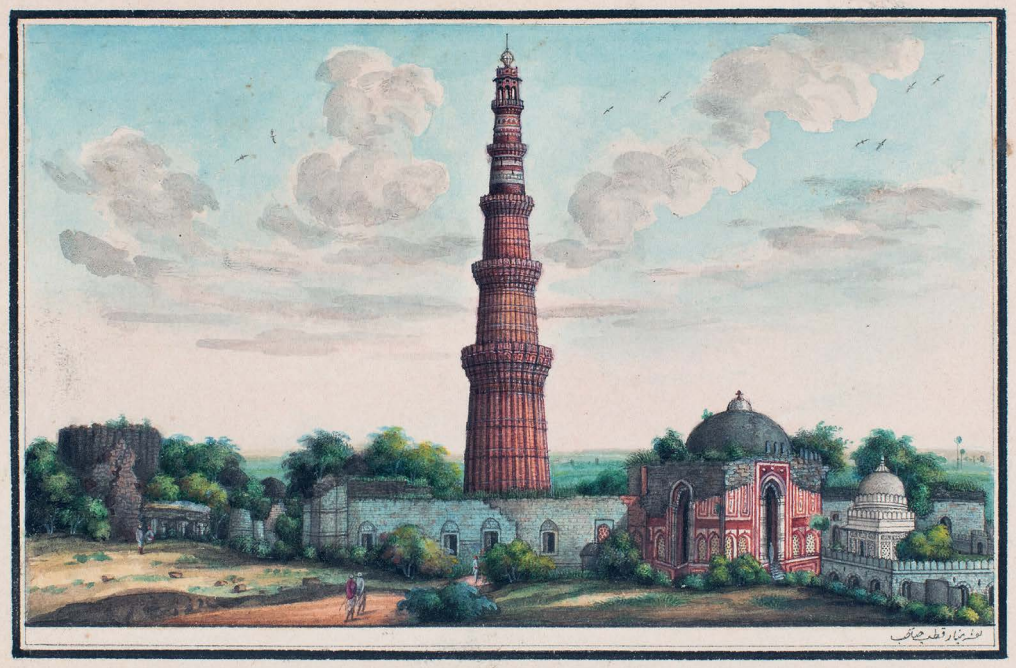




Among the first things you see in the DAG exhibition *Delhi Durbar: Empire, Display and the Possession of History* (on till November 6) is a watercolour-and-ink painting of the Qutub Minar from 1830, drawn by a Delhi artist. At first glance, you don't notice the unusual thing about it, but a closer look reveals the glaring idiosyncrasy. There's a cupola at the top of the monument, added by Major Robert Smith in 1829 and later removed in 1849, over complaints that the addition was incompatible with the tower's style. Details like this are what make *Delhi Durbar*, curated by Rana Safvi and Swapna Liddle, worth your while. Incidentally, this is the first DAG exhibition to be comprised entirely of in-house archival material; Safvi and Liddle selected and contextualised the documents, objects, photographs, artwork, etc. on display.

"The pictures and paintings you see in the exhibition are mostly about the pomp and the pageantry of the three Delhi Durbars," says Safvi. "Then, of course, there's the material pertaining to 1857, to the first war for Indian independence. Since most of the documentation around that time was done by the British themselves, this material has a bit of a colonial lens to it. The rest of the collection comprises material produced by both the British and Indian artists, photographers, kings, courtiers, sepoys and so on."

Safvi explains the exhibition is divided into three parts corresponding to the three Delhi Durbars—the first one in 1877, announcing Queen Victoria as the 'Empress of India', and then two more in 1903 and 1911, to mark the accession of Edward VII and George V, respectively. There are diaries, journals and paintings that depict various small battles during 1857, and much else besides. As Liddle explains in an essay that's included with the eponymous exhibition book, the Durbars were deemed necessary because the British wanted the Indian people to feel a sense of continuity in terms of transfer of power. Following courtly rituals and traditions,

BOOKS

The Many Cities of Delhi

Shama Mitra Chenoy's important new translation of Ramji Das's historic text throws light on Delhi as it was before 1857

Forever settling, settled and unsettling, Dilli, Delhi and Delhie has had a history of counting its ruins among its foundations, the future debris after its latest hubris.

As the latest Sarishtadar or record keeper, Shama Mitra Chenoy has dug up the 17th, 18th, 19th and early 20th centuries, not as an archaeologist, neither as a fictionaliser, but as a relay-historian. She has unearthed the best-known works about Delhi from the preceding centuries, studied them as a true historian would, to now hold out the baton to the 21st century. She wades across Dargah Quli Khan's *Muraqqa-e-Dehli*, through *Sair-ul-Manazil*, *Asar-us-Sanadid* to the works of Thomas Metcalfe, British Resident of Delhi as well as Ramji Das and Bashiruddin Ahmed Khan. To this, Mitra Chenoy adds her own scholarship–both original and translated. The result is a refreshing revival of three and a half centuries of lifestyle and a physical mapping of the once-happening places of Delhi as well as all that Delhi has lost.

One may be lured into the book as a lay reader, but it is the stuff of serious scholarship meant really for specialists. It would certainly attract INTACH, whose Delhi Chapter has attempted detailed listings. It should be of great interest to all town planners working in Delhi and the NCR keen to revive rather than obliterate the past.

What is truly admirable is the author's persever-